MAYAWATI: WOOING THE MUSLIMS PG 15

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BJP IN MP: THE GREAT TRIBAL OUTREACH PG 16

BENGALURU: A TERMINAL OF GRANDEUR PG 20



BHINDRANWALE 2.0? Amritpal Singh Sandhu, the head of Waris Punjab De, at the Golden Temple in Amritsar, Oct. 30

PRABHJOT GILL

PUNJAB

RADICAL THREAT

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

Punjab is witnessing a churn in Sikh politics, with moderates gradually losing their grip on the community amid the rise of radical elements. On November 13, the state's Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) government banned the public display of weapons and songs glorifying gun culture and violence in addition to ordering a review of all arms licences. The decision came hot on the heels of the state reporting two broad daylight murders—of Hindu right-wing leader Sudhir Suri in Amritsar and Dera Sacha Sauda follower Pradeep Kataria in Kotkapura—within a week, Suri's on November 4 and Kataria's six days later. Even as Canada-based gangsters Lakhbir Singh, a.k.a Landa Harike, and Satwinder Singh, a.k.a. Goldy Brar, have claimed responsibility for the two murders, respectively, the National Investigation Agency (NIA) suspects the crimes were carried out at the behest of Sikh radical groups.

Kataria, a dairy owner in Kotkapura town of Faridkot district, was an accused in one of the sacrilege cases that had rocked Punjab in 2015. That had put him on the hit list of Sikh radi-